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DeepL · Account security

Designing MFA account recovery from failed login to restored protection

I designed the sequence from a failed authentication code through email verification, reset guidance and a confirmed active state.

My role

Content designer for recovery entry points, verification, reset and re-enrollment states

Worked with

Security, product design, product management and engineering

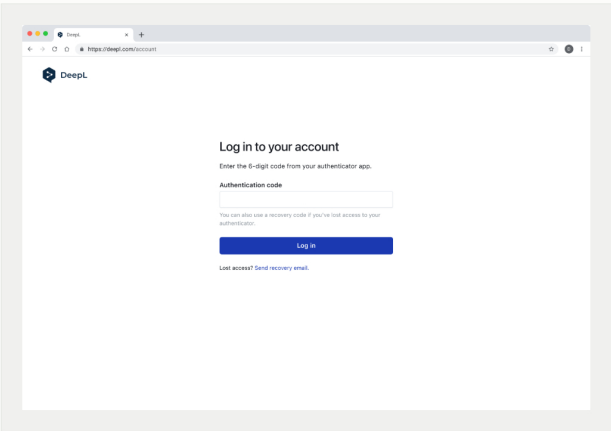
Why it mattered

People who had lost access to their authenticator needed a way back into their account without bypassing MFA.

01 · The experience

A recovery path that ends with MFA active again

Recovery entry point



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The standard login remains primary; recovery is placed where someone who has lost access needs it.

02 · The problem

People who had lost access to their authenticator needed a way back into their account without bypassing MFA.

MFA does its job by blocking access when the authentication code is unavailable or wrong. That same protection can strand a legitimate account owner who has lost their configured device.

The recovery copy therefore had to mark each change in security state: failed authentication, identity verification, MFA reset, re-enrollment and an active final state.

Constraint

The flow had to separate normal login from recovery, explain what email verification would change, invalidate the old authenticator entry and require a new setup.

04 · The judgment

The decisions doing the work

01

Keep the normal route intact

The authenticator code remains the primary action. Recovery appears as a deliberate fallback, not an equivalent way around MFA.

02

Offer recovery at the failure point

The error state separates retrying an incorrect code from sending a recovery email or contacting an admin.

03

Explain what verification triggers

The recovery screen says that a lost device leads to MFA being reset and set up again, so email verification is not mistaken for the end of the security journey.

04

Make the reset and final state explicit

The acknowledgement says the old authenticator entry no longer works; the settings state then confirms that MFA is active again.

The trade-off: The sequence asks users to read more during a high-friction moment; removing that explanation would make the transition from identity verification to MFA reset hard to understand.

05 - The sequence

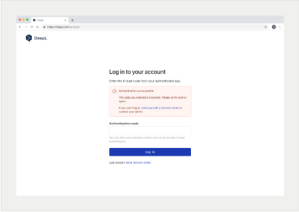
From failed authentication to an active security state

01	02	03	04	05
Try the configured method The normal authenticator step stays primary, with recovery available when access is lost.	Recover from a failed code The error distinguishes retrying from the two fallback routes: recovery email or admin support.	Verify by email A recovery code confirms identity and sets the expectation that MFA may need to be reset.	Reset and re-enroll The old authenticator entry is invalidated and the account must set up MFA again.	Confirm protection The account returns to an explicit Active state once setup is complete.

06 - The recovery flow

Each screen explains the next security transition

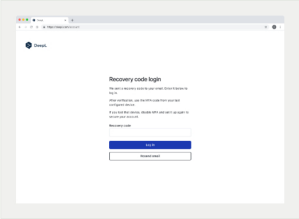
Failed authentication



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The error distinguishes a code retry from the recovery routes available when login is no longer possible.

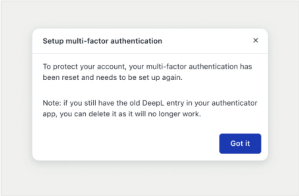
Email verification



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Verification is framed as one step in recovery, followed by an MFA reset and new setup when the device is gone.

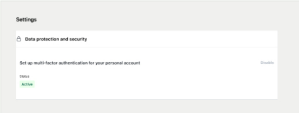
Reset explained



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The reset acknowledgement names both required follow-up actions: set up MFA again and discard the invalid old entry.

Protection restored



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The journey ends in settings with the security control visibly Active again.

07 - The outcome

What the work made possible

The flow gives a legitimate account owner a recoverable path while preserving the security model: verification does not end the journey; it leads to a reset, a new setup and an explicit active state.